



Robot for your home

The PR2 robot developed by Willow Garage is based on the Kinect sensor and can be used to help around the house <http://bit.ly/rjTrUo>

Kindle cloud reader

Amazon has launched its cloud reader service, enabling access to its ebook library via any HTML5 capable browser <http://bit.ly/n0w2Sh>

Developer corner

or clutter the interface by listing nearly all of them. What if the browser managed this and showed only the services you used and cared about?

On your desktop, this would be comparable to listing only Photoshop when you use GIMP or listing every application ever created for handling images.

On a similar note, why's it so difficult to associate your image files with web applications? Or to associate email links with your arbitrary web mail provider?

Services, stores and applications

The Google Chrome Web store already allows installation of web applications on a user's computer, albeit in a non-standard Chrome-specific way. A web store for web apps sounds good but until web applications aren't empowered a lot more; it's just a glorified way of creating bookmarks, nothing more.

Mozilla is working on a cross-platform, cross-browser, web-standard store and applications delivery mechanism but even that is dependant on web apps being a lot more capable.

service in a seamless manner. Web Intents is the term Google prefers to use, since it is similar to the concept of Intents on the Android platform, while Mozilla refers to them as Web Actions, but the concept is quite similar and in the process of being merged.

Web applications need a standard way to expose their capabilities, and to use the capabilities of other applications. For image data to work in your image editor, it will invoke the "image.get" service – this is comparable to a desktop application asking the OS to show the user a file browse dialog. Storage providers can then register themselves as providers for the "image.get" service.

Let's say you use SmugMug and Facebook for your images and have them installed on your browser. Now your online image editor application could simply show a button called "Open Image" or "Get Image" or the like. This button when clicked would show a list of all your installed applications that provide the "image.get" service and browse the files you've saved there. Images there will now open in your image editor. The

on other services for social networking, storage etc.

This approach isn't limited and can be extended to other common web activities such as sharing content or shortening URLs. In both cases, the services you use could be registered on your browser as service providers – for example "url.shorten" and "url.share" could be offered as options when you choose to share or shorten a link.

Payment processing, too, can be overhauled with this, as you can add PayPal, Moneybookers, Google Checkout, Amazon Payment, ClickandBuy or <insert your favorite or trusted payment processor here> to make payments for your online purchases. This, however, might be a little more complicated to handle, and might need more time to standardise.

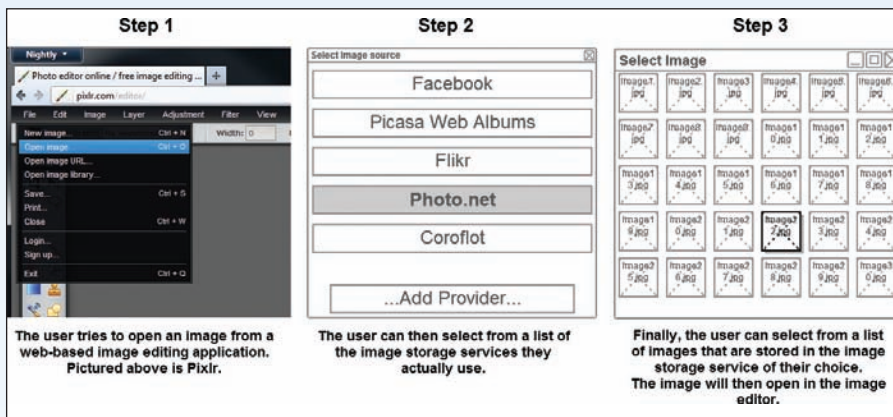
Conclusion

We can go a bit beyond this though, and think of even more applications. Why can't you use Google's Contacts system on other sites? Or use Yahoo's contact management system with Google? You could use one central contact management service that you like, and use it as a source for both, Gmail and Yahoo Mail! No need to enter the data again.

Or why be forced to use PayPal when there are many other, possibly better and cheaper, options out there?

In the end it is data from one service going to another service that needs it. As long as the data is yours, there should be no barriers on how you use it. Not only does this stand to change the way we use the web, but also have a deeper impact on the economy / ecosystem of the web. With such a standard system in place, it will be difficult for Service A and Service B to form a tie-up, at the cost of integration with Service C that you really use.

These standards are still in development, and Mozilla and Google have taken interest. There are sample web sites and applications that let you test these functionalities and get a peek at what the web might be like very soon. Internet speeds are increasing and web standards are evolving, but nothing has been more compelling a case for cloud computing than this. 



A rough representation of how this system might work. Note that the UI and interaction might be completely different in actual implementations.

These issues are central to the very concept of web applications, and quite obviously, the likes of Mozilla and Google are on the task, defining new mechanisms to give web applications some of the same powers we're used to in desktop applications. Both are working on a common specification and API for having applications register themselves as service providers, and handle this

image editors need not know which image storage solution is being used, nor does the image storage solution need to know where the image is actually going for editing.

This prevents new web applications from reinventing the wheel just to provide basic facilities already being offered by other applications. Your image editor can focus on editing images and rely